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Parties, persons, and one-at-a-time: conversation analysis and ELF

"Parties", Personen und "one-at-a-time": Konversationsanalyse und ELF

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Abstract: Drawing on an analysis of ELF data, this article deals with the characteristics and complexities of turn-taking in interactions involving three or more participants. Sacks et al.'s (1974) often quoted framework for turn-taking in conversations, which can still be regarded canonical reading in the conversation analytic literature, serves as a starting point for this investigation. The aim of this paper is to scrutinize the applicability of the turn-taking model for group interactions. A key concept in this regard is the notion of a *party*: the conversation analytic model for turn-taking posits that turn-taking does not take place between individual speakers, but between parties (hence the term *multi-party conversation*) which can potentially consist of several speakers (cf. Schegloff 1995: 32–33). In group interactions it is thus possible that overlap occurs among co-incumbents of the same party. This kind of simultaneous speech, however, has not yet been subject of systematic empirical analysis. The present paper offers a preliminary account of this aspect of turn-taking in multi-participant interaction by discussing data extracts from an ELF workplace meeting of seven speakers and suggests possible avenues for further research on the phenomenon.

Keywords: English as a lingua franca, conversation analysis, turn-taking, multi-participant interaction, "party"

Zusammenfassung: Anhand einer Analyse von ELF Daten beschäftigt sich dieser Artikel mit den spezifischen Charakteristika und Komplexitäten die sich für Turn-taking ergeben, sobald drei oder mehr TeilnehmerInnen an einem Gespräch beteiligt sind. Ausgangspunkt hierfür ist Sacks, Schegloff und Jeffersons (1974) Modell des Turn-taking in Konversationen, das bis heute einen oft zitierten Referenzpunkt in der linguistischen Forschung zu gesprochener Sprache darstellt

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und mit Recht als ein Standardwerk der konversationsanalytischen Literatur bezeichnet werden kann. Ziel dieses Artikels ist, die Anwendbarkeit des Modells auf Gruppengespräche zu diskutieren. Eine Schlüsselrolle kommt dabei dem Konzept der "party" zu: Die Konversationsanalyse geht generell davon aus, dass Turn-taking nicht zwischen Individuen stattfindet, sondern zwischen "parties", die potentiell auch mehrere SprecherInnen umfassen können (vgl. Schegloff 1995: 32–33). In Gruppengesprächen kann es daher zu Simultansequenzen zwischen den einzelnen SprecherInnen einer „party" kommen. Diese Art des Simultansprechens war bislang allerdings noch nicht Gegenstand systematischer empirischer Untersuchung. Anhand von Datenbeispielen aus einer Arbeitsbesprechung mit sieben SprecherInnen, die ELF als Verkehrssprache nutzen, soll in diesem Artikel die Komplexität von Turn-taking in Gruppengesprächen illustriert, die Anwendbarkeit des Konzeptes von "party" in der Analyse diskutiert und mögliche Wege für zukünftige Forschung auf dem Gebiet aufgezeigt werden.

Schlagworte: Englisch als Lingua Franca, Konversationsanalyse, Turn-taking, Gruppengespräche, "party"

1 Introduction

ELF research has so far largely been concentrating on spoken language data, mainly for the reason that "[s]poken interactions are immediate and at a remove from the stabilizing and standardizing influence of writing" as well as "overtly reciprocal and [...] thus facilitating observations regarding mutual intelligibility among interlocutors" (VOICE website: FAQs). One of the most influential theoretical frameworks in the study of spoken interactions is an approach that originated as a branch of sociology and came to be known as Conversation Analysis. It seems natural, then, that an intellectual exchange between these two areas of research might prove mutually benefitting in many ways. It is against this backdrop that the present paper should be seen as an attempt to promote fruitful dialogue between the research fields of English as a lingua franca (ELF) and Conversation Analysis (CA), which both share a prime interest in spoken language, albeit from different perspectives.

The motivation for writing this paper stems from the difficulties I had in applying the CA premise that participants in interaction take turns one-at-a-time to the analysis of English as a lingua franca data. These data consist of two audio-recorded workplace meetings among seven colleagues recorded in two internationally operating business organisations based in Vienna, Austria. In these data, overlap is a very prominent feature and yet, in many cases, does not

seem to be perceived as "violative" (Sacks et al. 1974: 724) by the interactants themselves, even though it does create problems for the analyst in attributing turns to individual speakers.[1] Since the participants prove to be expert-language users and highly effective communicators displaying their socio-pragmatic competence in many ways, it does not seem satisfactory to explain overlapping as the "under-attuning of individual turns" because of the ELF speaker's inability "to wait for and/or to project a suitable point of transitional relevance" (House 2008: 355). In search for an explanation of this phenomenon, I thus turned to the comprehensive body of conversation analytic work on overlap and its resolution.

What this paper suggests is that the number of participants to the interaction plays a vital role when it comes to the occurrence and interpretation of simultaneous speech. While Sacks et al. argue that, in principle, the turn-taking system "is compatible with different numbers of participants from conversation to conversation," they also acknowledge that "the system favors, by virtue of its design, smaller numbers of participants" (Sacks et al. 1974: 712). For reasons that will be discussed in more detail below, a greater number of participants hence introduces additional complexity to the allocation of speaking turns in verbal interaction. This arguably renders turn-taking more challenging for participants and analyst(s) alike, though, as stated above, their perspectives on this need not necessarily coincide.

One issue relevant for the allocation and distribution of speaking turns in interactions involving more than three participants is the possible existence of multi-person parties in interaction. As Schegloff observes, Sacks et al.'s turn-taking system "organizes the distribution of talk not in the first instance among persons, but among *parties*" (Schegloff 1995: 33, original emphasis). While it is "not uncommonly" the case that "parties are composed of persons – *single* persons," interlocutors may also organize themselves into "parties, such that there are fewer parties than there are persons" and hence "multi-person parties" may be involved in turn-taking (Schegloff 1995: 33, original emphasis). Consequently, two kinds of simultaneous speech are possible: overlap among co-incumbents of the same party and overlap across different parties. Though Schegloff (2000: 48) admits that "such occurrences have not been subjected to sustained empirical enquiry," he highlights that this distinction is crucial in "assessing the adequacy of the SSJ [Sacks et al. 1974] model" (Schegloff 1995: 35). The present paper is intended as a small contribution to this empirical enquiry.

While this article is concerned with some of the theoretical tenets of CA regarding the interactional practice of turn-taking, it should be noted that the

1 Cf. the similar problems Edelsky (1981) experienced in her analysis of faculty meetings involving 11 participants, which lead her to re-examine the nature of "the floor."

research project which triggered my interest in this matter was not from the outset designed as an investigation of this topic, but rather as a more general discourse analytic investigation into the pragmatic strategies ELF speakers in workplace meetings use to make their interactions communicatively successful and meaningful. While making reference to CA concepts, there is no claim therefore that the empirical part of this paper is in strict accordance with CA conventions of analysis. One definite limitation, for example, is the use of audio data instead of video data, which makes non-verbal features assumed to play a significant role in turn-taking, particularly gaze, inaccessible for the analysis. Naturally, this renders tentative any conclusions that can be drawn from the data. For reasons of confidentiality (as well as financial and practical constraints), video-recording was not an option at the time data collection was realized and priority was given to the authenticity of the data, i.e., audio-recorded authentic workplace interactions were preferred over video-recorded but simulated interactions.

A second potentially controversial issue from a CA perspective is the use of the VOICE transcription conventions (VOICE Project 2007), accessible online at the project's webpage, instead of Jefferson's (2004a) conventions accepted as standard in CA research. While those readers involved in or familiar with ELF research will be accustomed to the VOICE conventions, readers usually working within the research paradigm of Conversation Analysis might not. Since the former are assumed to represent the main readership of this journal, however, data will be presented using the VOICE conventions, the use of which is prevalent among ELF researchers. Albeit in different format, the VOICE transcription conventions capture relevant interactional features, such as simultaneous speech and rising and falling intonation, just as the transcription conventions used in CA do. In addition, they provide conventions for integrating features characteristic of ELF data such as pronunciation variations, coinages, or non-English speech.[2] Transcription undeniably constitutes the first step of data analysis and, as Silverman (2006: 207) points out, is not just "a technical detail prior to the main business of the analysis." However, transcription conventions are, after all, only just that: conventions. As such they might differ between research communities, as is the case with the conventions used by CA and ELF research, respectively. Heeding Buchholtz's argument that transcripts "are not transparent and unproblematic records of scientific research but [...] creative and politicized documents" (Buchholtz 2000: 1440) and as such always subjective and selective to a certain extent regardless of the conventions used,[3] it is argued

2 In addition, they offer the benefit of being computer readable, should the need for computer aided analysis arise, which is, however, not the case in this paper.

3 Provided, of course, the conventions used follow accepted academic standards.

that an analysis incorporating analytic concepts of CA is possible using other transcription conventions than those proposed by Jefferson.

The two examples discussed in this article are taken from an audio-recorded workplace meeting of seven colleagues at a bank who act as editorial board for an employee magazine. The participants have various first language backgrounds and use ELF as their shared medium of communication. Hence, the data constitute not only instances of group interactions, but also instances of institutional discourse in an intercultural setting, which raises the issue of the applicability of Sacks et al.'s (1974) turn-taking framework. In the original framework, Sacks et al. argue that talk in institutional settings, such as (formal) meetings, debates, interviews, or courtroom discourse, constitute separate "speech exchange systems" (Sacks et al. 1974: 701) displaying differences in their turn-taking systems. In a more recent paper, however, Schegloff et al. (2002) argue that, despite its name, CA is not only concerned with "conversations" in the sense of informal small-talk, but "extends to the study of talk and other forms of conduct (including the disposition of the body in gesture, posture, facial expression, and ongoing activities in the setting) in *all forms of talk in interaction*" (Schegloff et al. 2002, emphasis mine).

Therefore, while "ordinary conversation has a 'baseline' status in CA" (Seedhouse 2004: 1), this does not mean that non-conversational data cannot be studied using CA methodology. Quite clearly, workplace meetings exhibit – to a greater or lesser extent – certain peculiarities with regard to turn-taking which distinguish them from casual conversations (see, e.g., Holmes and Stubbe 2003; Asmuß and Svennevig 2009; Handford 2010). At the same time, as has often been pointed out (e.g., Brown and Yule 1983: 1; Pullin 2010: 458), the distinction between "casual conversation" on the one hand and "institutional discourse" on the other is to a large extent an artificially construed dichotomy for the sake of analytic convenience: Not only is much of institutional discourse "conversation like" (and the workplace meeting investigated in this paper is a case in point), but also many casual conversations exhibit "meeting like" characteristics as,[4] for instance, a family dinner-table conversation on organisational matters such as "Who is going to pick up the kids from school, take the dog to the vet and do the groceries for the weekend?". This illustrates that the borders between what can be termed "casual" and "institutional" discourse are in many cases fuzzy to begin with. What is more, even if the model's scope of application was originally

4 I am indebted at this point – and at many others in this paper – to Henry Widdowson for sharing his thoughts on countless matters regarding the contents of this article with me.

confined to casual conversations, Sacks et al.'s (1974) framework has since developed into a generic baseline for the description of turn-taking in all communicative contexts in linguistics. Consequently, whenever turn-taking in linguistics is analyzed, it is done with reference to Sacks et al.'s framework, regardless of the nature of the data.

As for the fact that the data are instances of intercultural lingua franca communication,[5] while CA has traditionally been an approach associated with monolingual (mostly American English) language use,[6] Schegloff does not "see that there is anything, in principle, that has to be different from other work in CA" when studying non-native talk (Schegloff interviewed by Wong and Olsher 2000: 113). It is therefore legitimate – and even corresponds with recent research developments in the field – to put conversation analytic principles to the test by applying them to intercultural and/or lingua franca data.

2 The conversation analytic turn-taking model of Sacks et al. (1974) and its application to group interactions

Turn-taking in linguistics can very generally be defined as "the process through which the party doing the talk at the moment is changed" (Goodwin 1981: 2). Although Erving Goffman coined the present day interpretation of turn-taking already in the 1950s,[7] linguists did not pick up on this interest in turn-taking until the late 1960s, when the issue was addressed by Harvey Sacks in his *Lectures on Conversation* (Sacks 1995 [1967]). Some years later, Sacks et al. still noted a distinct lack of empirical research into turn-taking and observed that "no systematic account [was] available" (Sacks et al. 1974: 698). Their paper finally provided just that, which probably explains the tremendous and long-lasting influence of the article.

5 Even though the cross-cultural validity of Sacks et al.'s turn-taking framework has repeatedly been questioned in the past, this issue will not be addressed in this paper, but see Wolfartsberger (2011a), Wolfartsberger (2011b), Santner-Wolfartsberger (2012), and Seidlhofer et al. (forthcoming) for a discussion of this matter.

6 However, over the last fifteen years or so, CA seems to have developed an interest in non-native or multilingual settings, as illustrated by literature on CA and Second Language Acquisition research (e.g., Markee 2000; Seedhouse 2005) or the organization of a colloquium on "New Directions in Conversation Analysis Research on L2" at the AAAL conference in March 2012.

7 See Goffman (1955): "On face work".

According to the framework, participants in spoken interaction take turns in occupying the conversational floor by uttering their contributions to the conversation. These contributions are called "turns" and are

> usually conceptualised in conversation analysis as stretches of talk by participants in verbal interaction which are concluded when the ongoing speaker is heard and/or seen to have completed what s/he was doing and then moves from the role of speaker to that of hearer. (Watts 1991: 37)

Thus, when the current speaker finishes her turn, the now vacant position of speaker is taken up by the former listener and a new turn by a new speaker is begun. Sacks et al. (1974: 700) argue that such turn transitions occur rapidly enough to avoid prolonged silence or gaps, but late enough to involve little or even no overlapping speech, which results in the fact that "overwhelmingly, one party talks at a time" in a single conversation (Sacks et al. 1974: 699, 706; see also Schegloff and Sacks 1973: 293).

According to Sacks et al. (1974), what makes it possible to achieve such smooth turn-transfer is the design of the turn-taking system that consists of various components, the first of which they term the "turn-constructional component" (Sacks et al. 1974: 702). By this they understand the fact that speakers may design their turns as various "unit-types," such as lexical, phrasal, clausal, or sentential constructions. This allows the hearer(s) to project the unit-type under way and predict the likely completion point of the current turn before the speaker has actually reached it. The projectability of turn constructions is of particular relevance for turn-taking because possible turn completion points constitute so-called transition-relevance places (TRPs), around which speaker shift takes place.

The second component of the system, which Sacks et al. call the "turn allocation component," comprises two basic groups of turn-transfer: (i) those cases where the next turn is allocated by the current speaker selecting a next speaker and (ii) those cases where one of the listeners self-selects as next speaker (Sacks et al. 1974: 702). The two components, the turn-constructional component and the turn-allocation component, are complemented by "a basic set of rules governing turn construction,[8] providing for the allocation of a next

8 Sacks et al. formulate these rules as follows: "(1) For any turn, at the initial transition relevance place of an initial turn constructional unit: (a) If the turn-so-far is so constructed as to involve the use of a 'current speaker selects next' technique, then the party so selected has the right and is obliged to take next turn to speak; no others have such rights or obligations, and transfer occurs at that place. (b) If the turn-so-far is so constructed as not to involve the use of a 'current speaker selects next' technique, then self-selection for next speakership may, but need not, be instituted; first starter acquires rights to a turn, and transfer occurs at that place. (c) If the turn-so-far is so

turn to one party, and coordinating transfer so as to minimize gap and overlap" (Sacks et al. 1974: 704).

In principle, Sacks et al. argue, the turn-taking system is "compatible with different numbers of participants from conversation to conversation" (Sacks et al. 1974: 712). However, they also note that there are certain limits as to what the system provides with regard to the number of interlocutors: "[t]hough the turn-taking system does not restrict the number of parties to a conversation it organizes, still *the system favors, by virtue of its design, smaller numbers of participants*" (Sacks et al. 1974: 712, emphasis mine). Perhaps not surprisingly, then, scholars investigating group interactions (e.g., Edelsky 1981; Kerbrat-Orecchioni 2004) have experienced challenges in analyzing their data. Kerbrat-Orecchioni, for instance, reports that trilogies, i.e., interactions involving three participants, are characterized by a "variability in alternation patterns" with regard to turn-taking, which manifests itself in a "lack of balance in floor-holding, violations of speaker-selection rules,[9] and interruptions and simultaneous talk" (Kerbrat-Orecchioni 2004: 4). This variability seems to increase with the number of participants, as she also notes that "[b]eyond four participants, the problems of describing the interaction increase dramatically" (Kerbrat-Orecchioni 2004: 7). The question of whether the number of interlocutors impacts in any way on the organization of turns at talk is therefore a relevant issue in need of further discussion.

Sacks et al. (1974) note a number of issues that need to be considered when dealing with turn-taking in group interactions. Probably the most obvious among them is the possibility of "schism of one conversation into more than one conversation" (Sacks et al. 1974: 713), i.e., the development of parallel conversations, in situations involving four of more interlocutors. Turn-taking in multi-participant interactions therefore involves the issue of regulating the "distribution of opportunities to talk among the several participants – including at times the forced draft of ones who appear in danger of drifting into schisms" (Schegloff 1996: 21). However, even if schisming does not occur, i.e., *within a single interaction*, the number of participants impacts in various ways on the allocation of speaking turns.

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constructed as not to involve the use of a 'current speaker selects next' technique, then current speaker may, but need not continue, unless another self-selects. (2) If, at the initial transition-relevance place on an initial turn-constructional unit, neither 1a nor 1b has operated, and, following the provision of 1c, current speaker has continued, then the rule-set a–c re-applies at the next transition-relevance place, and recursively at each next transition-relevance place, until transfer is effected" (Sacks et al. 1974: 704).

9 Kerbrat-Orecchioni (2004: 5), despite using the word *violations*, highlights that "[i]t should be noted that such intrusions do not always constitute real conversational offenses."

As mentioned above, one integral component of the turn-taking system is a basic set of rules governing turn design and speaker shift. This rule-set organizes only two speakers, namely "current" and "next." According to the rule-set, the "current speaker selects next" option has priority over the other selection techniques. This allows a "turn order bias" to occur which favors the "just prior to current" speaker to be selected as next speaker (Sacks et al. 1974: 708–709).[10] Therefore, as Sacks et al. (1974: 708) point out, "while turn order varies, it does not vary randomly" in group interactions.

Consequently, any participant currently not in the role of speaker who is interested in occupying the floor next will pay very close attention as to when the current speaker is coming to a possible completion, and hence a TRP, in order to be able to self-select before the current speaker selects a next speaker. At the same time, a current speaker who wants to choose the next speaker will have to select this next speaker before a possible transition relevance place in order to prevent another participant from self-selecting and taking over the turn at that point (Sacks et al. 1974: 713). The sequential rule of "first starter goes" will thus result in "pressure for minimization of turn size, distinctively operative with three or more parties" (Sacks et al. 1974: 713). Thus, in multi-participant interactions "a bias towards smaller turn size is introduced" (Sacks et al. 1974: 712).

The great achievement of Sacks et al.'s systematics for turn-taking lies in the fact that it uncovered the precision and orderliness underlying such a mundane activity as ordinary conversation. In this regard, as Oreström (1983: 29) points out, the framework represents "a valuable achievement as it contributes to the understanding of how conversation is systematically ordered." However, as he continues, although Sacks et al.'s work "is a great step towards such an understanding," the model has its "obvious limitations" (Oreström 1983: 29). One focal point of the critique of Sacks et al.'s (1974) turn-taking model addressed repeatedly in the literature revolves around the framework's conceptualization of simultaneous speech as a violation of the one-at-a-time principle that requires repair.

10 This turn order bias is only operative in group interactions: "In two-party conversation, the two speakers to whom the rule-set refers, and for whom the turn-order bias works, comprise all the parties to the conversation, and it is not in point to speak of a turn-order 'bias.' The 'last as next' bias, however, remains invariant over increases in the number of parties – and, with each additional increment in number of parties, tends progressively to concentrate the distribution of turns among a sub-set of the potential next speakers. With three parties, one might be 'left out' were the bias to operate stringently; with four parties, two would be 'left out,' etc." (Sacks et al. 1974: 712).

3 One-at-a-time in group interactions: parties or persons?[11]

The existence of unproblematic overlap even in dyadic interaction is a widely acknowledged feature, both within and beyond the CA research community. Ample research (e.g., Ford and Thompson 1996: 157–164; Gramkow Andersen 2001; Lerner 1993, Lerner 1996, Lerner 2002, Lerner 2004; Meierkord 2000; Tannen 2005) has demonstrated that, far from being a blatant or random violation of turn-taking rules, "speakers' production of simultaneous talk is ordered, consequential and functional, precisely in relation to the projectable linguistic and social unfolding of turns" (Ford et al. 2002: 8).

Presumably, the turn order bias and the bias towards smaller turn size operative in group interactions contribute to an even higher tendency for overlap to occur in group interactions. Kerbrat-Orecchioni (2004: 5), for instance, observes that "[t]he frequency of interruptions and simultaneous talk as well as the variety of ways in which these are carried out, increases in trilogues, and a fortiori in multi-participant interactions."[12] This does not mean that group interactions are *per se* characterized by more competitive turn-taking behavior than dyadic interactions. Kerbrat-Orecchioni refers to Müller (1995), who studied discussions among eight French students and reports an extensive use of overlap, mostly three or even four participants speaking at the same time. Despite the fact that these overlaps create a first impression of "unbearable cacophony," a detailed analysis reveals that they are "concerted" and "more often than not have a collaborative function" (Kerbrat-Orecchioni 2004: 5). Similarly, in an earlier study Edelsky (1981) found that in her data "there were many episodes for which a single floor holder could not be identified" (Edelsky 1981: 383). While these episodes were characterized by "much simultaneity, joint building of an answer to a question, collaboration on developing ideas [...], and laughter" (Edelsky 1981: 391), in many cases participants involved showed no sign of "battling" for the right to talk. Edelsky hence concluded that "[a] metaphor of competition may [...] be appropriate for one but not all ways of having the floor" (Edelsky 1981: 402).

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11 In this article, the term *party* is used as Schegloff (1995) understands it and *not* synonymously with the terms *person*, *speaker*, *participant*, *interactant*, etc., all of which refer to individuals.

12 Incidentally, Schegloff (2000) argues to the contrary that "[i]ncreases in the number of participants may increase the likelihood of the schisming of the conversation [...], but not of the number talking simultaneously in any *single* conversation" (Schegloff 2000: 48, emphasis mine), thus disagreeing with Kerbrat-Orecchioni (2004).

The discrepancy between the theoretical assumption of one-at-a-time in their model, and the reality of simultaneous talk in interactions was also acknowledged by Sacks, Schegloff, and Jefferson themselves, as can be seen by the continued work of Jefferson and Schegloff on overlap for decades after the appearance of their article in 1974 (e.g., Jefferson 1983a, Jefferson 1983b, Jefferson 1984, Jefferson 1986, Jefferson 2004b; Schegloff 1996, Schegloff 2000, Schegloff 2002). In later works, Schegloff (1995, Schegloff 2000) acknowledges the existence of unproblematic overlap and addresses certain aspects of the turn-taking organization with regard to overlap which have remained unclear due to "several underspecifications in our previous account of that organization" (Schegloff 2000: 42). He excludes four types of overlapping talk which are not taken as problematic by the interlocutors because "the simultaneous speakers do not appear to be contesting or even alternative claimants for a turn space" (Schegloff 2000: 42). These four exceptions are (i) backchannel utterances or "continuers," (ii) terminal overlaps,[13] (iii) choral forms of talk like laughter, collective greetings, or congratulations, and (iv) utterances that constitute conditional entry into a turn (cf. Lerner 1996) only, such as help in word search situations.

It can be expected that the greater the number of participants involved in talk-in-interaction, the greater the likelihood for these unproblematic categories of overlap to occur. After all, it makes a difference whether there is just one person present (apart from the current speaker) who may utter backchannels, or several persons. Similarly, terminal overlaps can be expected to increase in frequency when the number of participants increases, particularly when considering the effects of the turn order and turn size bias discussed above.[14] In extreme cases this might even lead to situations in which the occurrence of these four unproblematic cases of overlap is so frequent that it becomes "the rule" rather than "the exception" and thus conflicts with the claim that *overwhelmingly* one-at-a-time prevails in interaction. However, even if one excludes these four categories of "unproblematic overlap," cases of simultaneous speech persist which the turn-taking framework proposed by Sacks et al. (1974) cannot satisfactorily explain. So let us examine again what Schegloff himself has to say about one-at-a-time. At the very beginning of his article, Schegloff (2000) writes that the turn-taking organization

13 Terminal overlaps are cases "in which one speaker appears to be starting up by virtue of a prior speaker's analyzably incipient finishing of a turn" (Schegloff 2000: 5).

14 Cf. Sacks (1995 [1967]: 527): "[I]t's my suspicion that in multi-party conversations you get a lot of interruptions of the following sort: An utterance is coming to completion [...]. The next speaker starts to talk before it's completed."

> is an organization of practices designed to allow routine achievement of what appears to be overwhelmingly the most common default "numerical" value of speakership in talk-in-interaction: *one party* talking at a time. (Schegloff 2000: 1, emphasis mine)

In this quote it is obvious that Schegloff (2000) understands the one-at-a-time constraint to be operating between parties. Yet, on the next page, we find Schegloff arguing that

> [t]alk by more than *one person* at a time in the same conversation is one of the two major departures that occur from what appears to be a basic design feature of conversation, and of talk-in-interaction more generally, namely "one at a time" (the other departure is silence, i.e. fewer than one at a time). (Schegloff 2000: 2, emphasis mine)

Clearly, here Schegloff argues that one-at-a-time is to be understood as one-person-at-a-time. If we assume that *party* is synonymous with *person*, there is nothing to say against these quotations, apart from the fact that quite a number of scholars have found evidence in their data that interlocutors do *not* always orient to the one-at-a-time principle. However, the reader of Schegloff's article might be a bit puzzled to learn in note eight of the very same article that this obviously is not the case: a *party* is not necessarily the same as a person, as Schegloff talks about the fact that

> co-members of a party [...] may come to talk simultaneously because their party has been selected to speak next, but in a fashion that does not specify which of them is to do the speaking. (Schegloff 2000: 48, note 8)

According to Schegloff, such overlaps are "not infrequent" and "systematic products of a turn-taking organization which allocates turns to parties, but not necessarily among party-coincumbents" (Schegloff 2000: 48, note 8). Obviously, then, for Schegloff a *party* is not necessarily the same as a *person*, as a party may be composed out of several individuals acting as one party to talk-in-interaction. Though Schegloff (2000) admits that the issue has not yet been studied systematically, he refers to an earlier discussion of the matter (Schegloff 1995: 33–35) in which he discussed an extract taken from a conversation among four interlocutors in which overlap happens exclusively among co-incumbents of a single party. In that article Schegloff highlights again that

> the turn-taking system as described in SSJ organizes the distribution of talk not in the first instance among persons, but among parties. [...] on some occasions, or for some particular phase or topic sequence within some occasion of talk-in-interaction, the aggregate of persons who are, as Erving Goffman called them "ratified participants," are organized into parties, such that there are fewer parties than there are persons. (Schegloff 1995: 32–33)

In exchanges between two interactants the number of persons usually corresponds to the number of parties.[15] With three or more participants, this is not necessarily the case, as apparently several persons might form one party for a given stretch of talk. The conceptual distinction between *party* and *person* hence becomes only relevant if one deals with talk-in-interaction among more than two individuals. As Schegloff (1995) highlights, the possible existence of multi-person parties in group interactions has a bearing on the mechanisms for selecting a next speaker outlined in Sacks et al. (1974), as these mechanisms operate on the level of parties, not on the level of persons:

> If there are multi-person parties in the interaction, the turn-taking organization does not necessarily provide for the selection of a person to speak for the party, nor does it provide procedures for doing so (aside from a procedure, or device, for resolving overlapping talk if/when it arises [...]). (Schegloff 1995: 33)

Hence, while the turn-taking system outlined in Sacks et al. (1974) provides for the selection of a next *party*, it does not necessarily provide for the selection of an individual *speaker* for that party.[16]

For Schegloff (1995), the conceptual distinction between parties and persons is crucial in that it provides an opportunity to further defend Sacks et al.'s (1974) turn-taking model and to refute criticism brought forward against one-at-a-time:

> In *assessing the adequacy of the SSJ model* of turn-taking, such considerations will be important, for without them we will not properly appreciate the character of different kinds of simultaneous talk for the participants, and therefore their different bearing on assessment of the model. (Schegloff 1995: 35, original emphasis)

While Schegloff's observations on the possibility of multi-person parties in group interactions are no doubt valuable, I find his line of argument slightly perplexing, for various reasons. First, it is unclear to me whether one-at-a-time is to be understood now as one-*party*-at-a-time or one-*person*-at-a-time since both

15 As one reviewer remarked, it is not entirely clear whether multi-person parties are an exclusive feature of group interactions, or whether it is theoretically possible that two individuals engaged in dyadic interaction may organize themselves into one two-person party for a given time in the interaction. This, however, would leave this two-person party temporarily without a counterpart, which makes it hard to imagine how this two-person party should still engage in verbal *interaction* if there is no other person or party to interact with. This is why I take the possible existence of multi-person parties to be a feature of group interactions only.

16 The issue is discussed in greater detail in Lerner (1993: 227).

phrases are used by Schegloff (2000). Second, I cannot quite see why Schegloff (1995) establishes the distinction between party and person and then, in his account of overlap resolution (Schegloff 2000), goes back to equating parties and persons, as we have seen in the above quotations, without discussing his motivations for doing so. Finally, I would argue that it is contestable to claim, on the one hand, that turn-taking operates between parties (not speakers), but simultaneously argue, as Schegloff does, that the underlying principle participants orient to when taking turns at talk is one-*speaker*-at-a-time, and not one-*party*-at-a-time. The resolution of this issue, however, seems to be crucial in order to be able to investigate turn-taking and simultaneous speech in group interactions.

Given the fact that Sacks et al.'s original framework does not mention the distinction between party and person at all, and that Schegloff uses the terms *party* and *person* interchangeably in his later work on overlap resolution (Schegloff 2000, Schegloff 2002), it is not surprising that the issue seems to have escaped the attention of researchers. Similarly, the terms *multi-party* and *multi-participant* talk seem to be used interchangeably in the literature. The only instance of addressing the distinction between person and party I am aware of is found in Kerbrat-Orecchioni's (2004) account of research on "polylogues," i.e., interactions among three or more participants, carried out by herself and her colleagues. She rejects the idea that turn-taking operates between parties in Schegloff's (1995) sense on grounds that will be discussed in further detail below, arguing that "the succession of turns is first and foremost a phenomenon which takes place between individuals" (Kerbrat-Orecchioni 2004: 3). Apart from this brief discussion, the concept of party as potentially encompassing several interlocutors in group interactions seems not to figure in the literature concerned with turn-taking in spoken interaction.[17] Nevertheless, its implications for group interactions are considerable.

17 The only other publication referring to Schegloff's distinction between *party* and *person* is Lerner's (1993) article on "Collectivities in action," which appeared two years before Schegloff (1995). Lerner refers to Schegloff's (1995) paper as being "in press" and "forthcoming." Obviously, Lerner had access to Schegloff's then unpublished article, which suggests that Lerner and Schegloff were working on the issue together. This assumption is strengthened by the fact that a data extract discussed in Lerner (1993) re-appears in a slightly modified form in Schegloff (1995). While Lerner (1993) discusses instances of selecting several speakers as "next" similar to the ELF data extracts in this paper, he does not relate the issue of party to the one-at-a-time principle.

4 So "why that now"? Implications for investigating turn-taking in groups

Though seemingly only a minor issue, the distinction between *party* and *speaker* as postulated by Schegloff (1995) is not without consequences. It can hardly be denied that such a distinction would cast many of the principles laid out in Sacks et al. (1974) in a new light. This holds true for basically all studies that have investigated turn-taking in group interactions so far and have treated parties as synonymous with individual participants. Some might say that one should think twice before doing this only because an individual researcher, even if this individual researcher is Emanuel Schegloff, differentiates between parties and participants in one article. If we pretend not to have read Schegloff (1995) and go back to equating parties with persons, so one might argue, then all is well.

Such a line of argumentation, however, ignores the fact that over the years considerable evidence has come to the fore that the conversation analytic turn-taking model with its underlying assumption of one-at-a-time (interpreted as one *speaker* at a time) cannot always explain what analysts find in their data. The notion of party as potentially encompassing several individuals might offer an explanation for the frequent occurrence of overlap and the different reactions it triggers by the interactants, who sometimes orient to it as interruptive, and sometimes as collaborative, and sometimes even in both ways (cf. Tannen 1994). A distinction between *party* and *person* implies that there are two different types of overlap possible in interaction: overlap of party co-members, and overlap of speakers belonging to separate parties. If we understand the one-at-a-time constraint to be operating between parties, but not between speakers, as in the first quote from Schegloff (2000) above, then overlap among party co-members would be in conformity with the rules set out in Sacks et al. (1974), whereas overlap across parties would constitute a violation of these turn-taking rules. At least, that is the direction in which Schegloff (1995) seems to argue:

> Consequently, in understanding the interactional significance of simultaneous talk-in-interaction, and in appreciating its relevance of the assessment of models of turn-taking, one important discrimination will be between simultaneous talk between coincumbents of a single party on the one hand, and between separate parties on the other. (Schegloff 1995: 33)

He also claims that in sequences where there is frequent overlap "much, and often all, of the simultaneous talk is between participants who, at the moment in the conversation, are co-incumbents of a party" (Schegloff 1995: 33). It is not

clear, however, to what extent this claim is based on systematic empirical investigation. In any case such an argumentation suggests that overlap among co-party members is not treated as a violation of turn-taking rules, whereas overlap across parties is. One wonders if the difference between overlap perceived as "interruptive" and overlap perceived as supportive then should be conceptualized in the way that the intervening speaker is a member of a different party in the case of an "interruption" and a co-incumbent of the same party in the case of, e.g., a supportive completion.

The crucial question that poses itself, however, is how a party is defined. Unfortunately, there is only little information provided by Schegloff (1995: 34–35) on this crucial question. He argues that participants may form a party in interaction "by virtue of interaction-specific contingencies and conduct" (Schegloff 1995: 33). This

> can involve their relative alignment in current activities, such as the co-telling of a story or siding together in a disagreement, or their several attributes relative to a momentarily current interactional contingency, for example, whether they are host or guest, whether – as a new increment is being added to a number of interactional participants – they are the newly arrived or pre-present. (Schegloff 1995: 33)

In order to illustrate this, Schegloff discusses one extract of data where four interactants are divided up into a party of "the informed" versus a party of "the uniformed." Hence, all we learn about the concept of party is that for Schegloff it is not a stable concept that remains the same throughout the interaction. As "people can come and go in the course of talk-in-interaction" (Schegloff 1995: 35), it follows that even if the overall number of participants in a single conversation remains the same,

> the number of parties into which those participants may be seen to be organized (because they see *themselves* so to be organized, and embody that stance in their conduct) can change continuously as the contingencies of the talk change, [...]. (Schegloff 1995: 35, original emphasis)

Schegloff obviously views a party as something that is constantly in flux throughout the interaction, as well as something that needs to be enacted by the interactants and – presumably – also negotiated. While the concept of party seemingly explains why not all cases of overlap are treated as a violation of turn-taking rules by the participants, it raises a host of other questions. One of them is how the concept of party relates to other groupings of interlocutors, which have been studied by various researchers (e.g., Bruxelles and Kerbrat-Orecchioni 2004; Kangasharju 1991, Kangasharju 1996; Knoblauch 1991; Kotthoff 1992; Lerner 1993) and referred to as *coalition, alliance*, *ensemble, association*,

and *interactional team*, an issue I will come back to in the final section of this paper. Clearly, a systematic empirical exploration of the phenomenon is needed.

While the present paper cannot offer an exhaustive account, the discussion of data extracts taken from ELF group interaction, tentative as it may be, is intended to draw attention to the distinction between party and participant in group interactions. As the paper suggests, not only might the high frequency of overlap found in the data be explained by the increased number in participants, but the perception of many of these overlaps as unproblematic and non-violative by the participants may be explained by the fact that these overlaps do not violate the one-at-a-time principle stipulated in Sacks et al. (1974) if one-at-a-time is perceived as one *party* at a time, not as one *speaker* at a time. Put differently, if overlap occurs among speakers perceiving themselves as belonging to the same party, then it would be in conformity with Sacks et al.'s framework and thus non-violative. This would help to reconcile the theoretical claims made about one-at-a-time in Sacks et al.'s framework with the observations of unproblematic overlap in the data.[18]

5 Some empirical observations on overlap among party co-incumbents in ELF

As mentioned before, one issue that needs to be reconsidered in light of parties potentially encompassing several individuals is the issue of selecting "a next" to talk. According to Sacks et al. (1974), the turn-allocation component comprises two basic groups of turn-transfer possible in group interaction: (i) those cases where the next turn is allocated by the current speaker selecting a next speaker and (ii) those cases where one of the listeners self-selects as next speaker (Sacks et al. 1974: 702). If turn-transfer may happen, however, not only between *speakers* but also between *parties* consisting of several speakers, the picture becomes more complex: The current speaker may indeed select a next *speaker*, i.e., one individual. However, he or she may also select a next *party* consisting of several individual speakers (cf. Lerner 1993: 227–228). This turn-allocation by the current speaker would then only be a first step in selecting a next *speaker* to talk. The

18 Needless to say, the participants' assessment of a given overlap as (non)-violative is not directly accessible, but only via data analysis. There is always the risk of the analyst's interpretation not being in conformity with the participants' interpretation, even though CA seeks to arrive at maximum congruence between these potentially diverging interpretations by close micro-analysis of the details in talk-in-interaction.

second step would consist of the "co-incumbents" of the selected party to come to an agreement as to who is to do the talking for the party.

This would be the case, at least, if we want to hold on to the principle of one-at-a-time interpreted as one-*speaker*-at-a-time. If we allow more than one speaker talking at a time to be in conformity with the turn-taking framework, then the co-incumbents of the party selected could speak simultaneously or, probably more likely, co-construct the next speaking turn. In principle, the same holds true for self-selection, where it is possible that a next party (consisting of several individual speakers) self-selects at a TRP and either co-constructs the next turn or utters it in overlap.

One next-speaker selection technique is to use "a first member of one of those pairs" that belongs to a class of paired-utterances in order to select a next speaker who then produces a second member of the pair out of a "group of alternative classes of appropriate next utterances" (Sacks 1992 [1967]: 667). Asking a question is one possible realisation of this technique.[19] In dyadic interaction, a question by the current speaker automatically selects the second interlocutor as the next speaker, whereas in group interactions, this is only the case if the question is specifically addressed to a specific individual. The situation is somewhat different, though, if the question is not addressed to a particular person, but to a sub-set of speakers. Consider the following example: Right before the extract occurs, S1 and S2 are engaged in a discussion of an article S2 intends to write for the next issue of the employee magazine the meeting participants are editing. The article will be about a corporate event called "emotion day" and S1 and S2 are discussing details regarding the article's topical focus, i.e., that it should address aspects of the "strategy" behind this event, and not just the event itself. At the end of this discussion S1, the chairperson, utters a question enquiring what the title of the article will be, so that she can add it to her notes about the magazine's next issue. The extract below starts with this question.

(1)	1	S1:	thanks (1) so (.) how should we call it? emotion day?=
	2	S2:	=emotion day.
	3	S1:	and strategy?
	4	S2:	yeah mhm (11)
	5	S1:	thanks a lot
	6	S2:	<soft>(no problem)</soft>

19 In addition to selecting a next party to speak, asking a question puts some kind of constraint on the next speaker/party as to what is to be done in the ensuing turn (cf. Sacks [1992 (1967)]: 673), i.e., providing an answer or orienting to the question in some other way.

7	S3:	we actually had information in in our magazine <6>about
8		emotion day so</6> i think it should be more (.) about
9		<soft>strategy</soft>=
10	S2:	<6>mhm (.) i know</6>
11	S1:	=yeah i think (.) i think too (.)
12	S2:	<1>yeah (.) i will do my best</1>
13	S1:	<1>because the people already</1> read it in the (.) in the
14		[name of magazine] in the <L1de>[German name of maga-
15		zine]</L1de> (.) <2>and saw the photos and</2>
16	S2:	<2>mhm i know so i i</2> it was not my idea
17	S1:	<3>yeah</3>
18	S2:	<3>it was the</3> idea from the top management <4>so i</4>
19	S4:	<3>@@@@</3>
20	S1:	<4>yes</4> it's a it's a good idea
21	S2:	yeah
22	SS:	@@@@@
23	Sx-f:	always (.) always
24	SS:	@@@@@@@@@@
25	S1:	@@@ <@>always okay</@> @@=
26	S2:	=but i know our concerns and i will (.) really try to (.)
27	S5:	not to write too much about the delicious buffet <5>@@@@</5>
28	S3:	<5>@@@@@</5>
29	S2:	<5>no (xx) really not</5>
30	S1:	and strategy
31 →	S5:	do you really want to call it emotion day and strategy?
32	S1:	<6>(this will be) (xxxxx)</6>
33	S2:	<6>this is just our working title</6> <7>how the the how the
34		</7> the the article will be named (.)
35	S2:	<1>i can think about it</1>
36	S5:	<7>this is the working title</7>
37	S1:	<1>yeah (.) yeah</1>
38	S2:	this is just a working title (5)
39	S1:	[S7]?

Lines 1–6 of the extract are taken up by a sequence in which S1 and S2 mutually agree to refer to the article by "emotion day and strategy": after asking the question as to the article's title in line 1, S1 sets out to answer it herself by suggesting calling the article "emotion day". The tentativeness of this suggestion is indicated by her use of rising intonation, represented as a question mark

in the transcript, which makes relevant some kind of reaction to this suggestion by S2. Indeed, S2 immediately responds to this by an affirmative repetition of "emotion day" with falling intonation,[20] thus signalling her content with S1's suggestion. In line 3, S1 proposes to add "and strategy" to the title, thereby rendering her suggested title incomplete. Again, this is done with rising intonation emphasizing the tentative nature of her suggestion. S2 again reacts affirmatively, by uttering "yeah mhm" in line 4, followed by a very long pause of 11 seconds.[21] The fact that S2 does not use this time to add anything to this matter is taken as an indication that she is content with this title as well. This is also the way S1 interprets this pause, as she utters "thanks a lot" in line 5, thus treating the topic of the article's title as complete and thanking S2 for her readiness to contribute this article to the next issue of the magazine, to which S2 responds with a soft "no problem".

Uttering some statement of gratitude *vis á vis* her conversational partner(s) is repeatedly employed by S1 in this meeting as a "topic closing" statement before she moves on to a next issue. This hint of imminent topic change is taken up by S3 in line 7, who uses the opportunity to voice her concerns that the article might overlap with other articles on the topic of "emotion day" that have already appeared. The ensuing lines 8–29 are mainly dealing with her concerns, resulting in a humorous sequence in which S2 defensively makes clear that it was not her idea to write this article, but that the initiative comes "from the top management" (line 18). In line 31, and this is the most relevant part of the extract now, S5 returns to the topic of the article's title by asking the question "do you really want to call it emotion day and strategy?", thus making use of a "first pair utterance" to select a next party to speak.

As mentioned in the introduction of this paper, the data consist of audio-recorded and not video-recorded interactions, which represents a definite drawback for the analysis of the phenomenon in question. In all likelihood, whenever a party of several co-incumbents is selected, gaze of the current speaker as well as of the co-incumbents selected will be an important means in deciding who is to talk and should be factored into the analysis. However, in this particular case there is – as we have seen – an on-record evidence of who decided to refer to the article in question by "emotion day and strategy" in the transcript. As we saw at the beginning of the extract, this title was mutually agreed on by S1 and S2.

20 The immediacy of the response is marked by = signs in the transcript.

21 While S2's affirmative response to adding "and strategy" to the title in line 4 may arguably be interpreted as less strong than her positive reaction to the first part of the title in line 2, this 11 second pause would grant her ample opportunity to voice her concerns about adding "and strategy" to the title.

Consequently, the party selected to answer that question can be identified as consisting of these two speakers.

This corresponds also with the participants' interpretation, as we can see that S1 and S2 simultaneously address the question (lines 32 and 33). S2 in line 32 states that this is just "our working title", thus stressing the provisional character of the title as well as the fact that it was mutually agreed on (by using the possessive pronoun *our* title). Her response overlaps entirely with S1's answer to the question in line 32, which is, admittedly, overwhelmingly unintelligible. The most likely beginning of her reply is transcribed as "this will be", followed by five unintelligible syllables. As analysts, we can only speculate about what she says. However, her response is quite obviously one supporting the proposition by S2, i.e., the provisional character of the title: when S2 elaborates on her initial answer "<7>how the the how the</7> the the article will be named (.) <1>i can think about it</1>", S1 uses affirmative backchannels ("yeah (.) yeah") in line 37. This strongly indicates that S1 supports S2's position that the title may still be changed. Also, when S2 states again that "this is just a working title" (line 38), S1 does not see the need to add anything to this, as is indicated by a relatively long pause of five seconds following S2's concluding statement in line 38. Instead, we can see S1 moving on to the next topic, the article S7 will write for the magazine, in the last line of the extract above, which suggests that the matter is now settled for everybody involved.

The suggested interpretation of overlap in this episode is hence that S5's question in line 31 selects a party of two (i.e., S1 and S2) as next to speak. S1 and S2 both attend to S5's question in the same way and simultaneously. The resulting overlap (lines 32 and 33) is comparatively long (eight syllables or "beats"), suggesting that it is not treated by the speakers involved as a situation that needs to be immediately resolved. Admittedly, S1's utterance is not fully comprehensibly, so it might be that she drops out before reaching a point of syntactic completion, i.e., stops talking to "repair" an occurrence of more than one-speaker-at-a-time perceived as problematic. However, the eight "beats" she utters in overlap with S2 are more than enough to utter a syntactically complete response to the question by S5, in case she does not see the need to drop out prematurely. The fact that in lines 31–37 overlap happens mainly between S1 and S2 as the co-incumbents of the party selected to speak (the exception being the overlap labelled <7></7>, which is caused by S5's showing comprehension of the title's provisional character),[22] might explain why this incidence of simultaneous speech does seem to be treated as unproblematic by the participants involved.

22 Note that this overlap, though S5 shows support for S2's proposition, does seem to cause slight irritation on the part of S2, who "outwaits" it by repeating the words "how the the how the </7> the

The second extract also depicts a situation in which overlap seems to be caused by the fact that a question is directed at more than one individual speaker. The participants are discussing an article S3 intends to write about a debt advisory center run by the bank as a corporate social responsibility measure. During this discussion S1 runs into a lexical problem and cannot recall the word *challenge*. She thus utters a request for lexical assistance (line 7) by code switching into her mother tongue German and asking the question <L1de>was heißt herausforderung?</L1de> [How do you say *Herausforderung*?]. As we can see, S2 and S5, both fellow German speakers, come to her assistance and supply the English word for *Herausforderung* ('challenge') in overlap (lines 9 and 10).

(2)
1 S1: mhm (.) and i think important is that it is unique and why is it
2 <5>unique</5>
3 S3: <5>yes</5>
4 S1: that is a (.) a main (2) point i think
5 S3: which can be (1) interesting for other countries maybe
6 S5: <6>mhm yes as a role model mhm</6>
7 → S1: <6>yeah (.) mhm (.) mhm</6> (8) and maybe what was the
8 <L1de>was heißt Herausforderung?</L1de>
9 → S2: <1>challenge</1>
10 → S5: <1>the challenge</1>
11 S1: the challenge er to (.) erm (2) introduce this program

While situations of word search are nothing remarkable, both in ELF and monolingual contexts, there are several aspects to be noted about this short episode. The first one is relevant not only in group interactions, but in dyadic interactions as well. It concerns the status of S2 and S5's utterances providing lexical help within the turn-taking framework in so far that the utterances in lines 9 and 10 do not constitute speaking turns in their own right. Whoever decides to pick up on S1's request for lexical assistance is likely to be granted "conditional access" to the turn by S1 only (cf. Schegloff 1995; Lerner 1996, Lerner 2002). This subsumes situations in which

> a speaker of a not possibly completed turn-in-progress yields to another, or even invites another to speak in their turn's space, conditional on the other's use of that opportunity to further the initial speaker's undertaking. (Schegloff 1995: 36, emphasis mine)

According to Schegloff, word search is one of the two "most familiar" (Schegloff 1995: 36) cases of this. In the present example, the latter of the two cases

the" in line 32. Following the suggested interpretation, a possible explanation would be that S5 does not belong to the party consisting of S1 and S2, i.e., that this overlap happens *across* parties.

described by Schegloff above seems to apply: S1 does not *yield* her turn, as can be seen by her continuation of the turn in line 11 after lexical help has been provided. Rather, her request for help in lines 7 and 8 serves as a "method [...] for gaining the co-participation of recipients by eliciting conditional entry into [her] turn space" (Lerner 2002: 22). While it is thus clear that S2 and S5 are temporarily speaking within S1's turn space and not their own, it is less clear what their speaking *in overlap* in a turn-space that belongs to S1 means for the assessment of this overlap with regard to one-at-a-time.

As discussed in Section 3 above, Schegloff (1995: 36) exempts overlap occurring as a result of conditional entry to the turn from the one-at-a-time principle. Presuming a dyadic exchange, he notes that "should the initial and subsequent speaker end up talking at once, this is generally treated (by them) as noncompetitive and non-problematic" (Schegloff 1995: 36). This is, however, not the case in the example above. In Extract (2), overlap does not occur among S1, the initial speaker, and a second speaker providing lexical help, but it occurs among two speakers simultaneously providing lexical assistance (lines 9 and 10). The overlap among S2 and S5 in the extract above is hence *not* exempted from one-at-a-time by Schegloff (1995, Schegloff 2000), which suggests that it should be treated as violative by the participants. There is, however, no indication of this in the transcript: S1 takes over the word *challenge* suggested by two of her co-participants and continues with her turn straight away. Also, there is no indication in the transcript that S2 and S5 are competing for turn space (which would, incidentally, raise the theoretical problem of how S2 and S5 could possibly compete for a turn that is not theirs but S1's in the first place).

The question is hence how to account for such an unproblematic overlap by reference to the conversation analytic turn-taking model. A first, rather mundane, point is that such a situation can only occur in group interactions, since it takes three or more individuals in order for two to overlap in providing assistance with the turn of a third speaker. This particular kind of simultaneous speech is therefore once again a peculiarity of verbal interaction in groups. A second point worth mentioning is S1's use of code-switching into her mother tongue German when uttering the request for lexical assistance. As ELF researchers will know, such an incorporation of linguistic competence other than competence in English is nothing unusual in English as a lingua franca communication. In this particular case, however, it takes on additional significance as an indication of whom S1 directs her request for assistance to: quite obviously only those of her interlocutors who are able to understand German, maybe even only those speaking it as their first language.

Once again, due to the lack of video data, it cannot be assessed with certainty who is the intended recipient of S1's call for lexical assistance. This would arguably be possible if the data were video recorded and an analysis of

gaze direction yielded that S1 looks at, say S2, exclusively and not at S5 at all. In such a case, her request for assistance could in all likelihood be characterized as intended for S2 to answer, and not for S5.[23] Without the availability of visual information all we can say is that S1's request for help makes relevant an orientation to her request by a sub-set of participants only, i.e., those able to identify her utterance as what it is (i.e., seeking lexical assistance) and possessing the linguistic knowledge to attend to it. While it might be debatable whether S1's request selects a multi-person party consisting of "those knowing German" as next to speak, or whether it just limits the number of speakers who can self-select for speakership to those knowing German,[24] it is clear that by code-switching into her mother tongue German S1 "conjointly address[es] co-participants as an association, thereby establishing the relevance of a multi-person unit of participation" (Lerner 1993: 220), the relevant multi-person unit of participation in this case consisting of everybody possessing sufficient knowledge of German in order to deal with her request. The fact that S2 and S5, both native speakers of German, belong to said multi-person unit suggests that their overlap in lines 9 and 10 is unproblematic precisely because it occurs *within* the very multi-person unit S1 has established as relevant for the interaction, i.e., a party of speakers knowing German. Once again, then, the concept of a multi-person party as a relevant unit for the interactional practice of turn-taking might serve to reconcile the theoretical framework of Sacks et al. (1974) with the observed occurrence of overlap in the data and participants' orientation towards it as unproblematic.

6 Discussion, conclusion, and outlook

The discussion of the specificities of turn-taking in group interactions in Sections 2–4 as well as the preliminary analysis of the two data extracts

23 Chances are, however, that S1 might not care whether S5 attends to her request for assistance, even if it was intended for S2. Dausenschön-Gay and Krafft (1991: 148–149, referred to in Kerbrat-Orecchioni 2004: 5) argue that in certain situations speakers follow an "efficiency rule" rather than the selection rules outlined in Sacks et al. (1974): "If for example I ask A what time it is, I will be completely satisfied if it is B who answers me" (ibid., translated from the French by Kerbrat-Orecchioni 2004: 5).

24 It is further questionable whether the mechanisms for selecting a next to talk outlined in Sacks et al. (1974) apply at all to utterances that constitute invited entry into another's turn space, and not separate speaking turns in their own right. This issue, however, has nothing to do with the distinction of *party* and *participant* and a discussion of it would exceed the scope of this paper.

taken from ELF group interaction in Section 5 suggest that turn-taking in group interactions does indeed exhibit certain peculiarities which impact on the occurrence and interpretation of simultaneous speech. The concept of a party as potentially encompassing several individual speakers might offer a possibility to account for some of the problems researchers dealing with multi-participant interactions have experienced in applying the turn-taking model of Sacks et al. (1974) to their data (e.g., Edelsky 1981; Kerbrat-Orecchioni 2004). The distinction between overlap *within* parties as opposed to overlap *across* parties may help in coming to terms with the very different, sometimes even antipodal, reactions interlocutors show towards simultaneous sequences.

At the same time, the concept of party, as was already alluded to, raises a myriad of questions as to how it can be implemented as a useful concept in the empirical analysis of turn-taking in group conversations. One question is whether a party of several speakers should be conceptualized along the lines of other groupings of participants, such as *coalitions* or *teams*, that might be formed in group interactions. In fact, the examples Schegloff (1995: 33) gives for "interaction-specific contingencies and conduct" leading to the possible formation of parties, e.g., "siding together in a disagreement" or co-telling a story, are very diverse and partly coincide with the contingencies other researchers have described as motivations for coalition forming.

In order to speak of a coalition or team, participants need to openly establish their association and make it visible (cf. Bruxelles and Kerbrat-Orecchioni 2004; Kangasharju 1996). Among the devices participants use in order to make their coalition manifest are agreement markers, prompting or lexical assistance, as well as assistance in speech acts and argumentation (Bruxelles and Kerbrat-Orecchioni 2004: 77), all of which quite likely result in a higher frequency of co-constructed turns and simultaneous sequences. When alliances or coalitions emerge, turns may become co-authored by several speakers or speakers may expand a previous speaker's turn in order to support the point the previous speaker has made. Kangasharju (1996: 292) notes "that members of the same team often continue, complete or repair each other's turns or [...] take a turn on behalf of another member of the team." Therefore, "the participants' interpretation of what is going on concerning coalition-forming has a direct influence on turn-taking order" (Bruxelles and Kerbrat-Orecchioni 2004: 83).

Nevertheless, it is clear for Kerbrat-Orecchioni (2004: 3) that "turn-taking operates per se between speakers," not parties. After all, "[w]hereas the number of participants in a polylogue is an objective fact, 'parties' can only be determined from a specific point of view" (Buxelles and Kerbrat-Orecchioni 2004: 110). Thus, for her "[t]he notion of 'party' [...] belongs to another level of

analysis" (Kerbrat-Orecchioni 2004: 3). Even though there is no explicit reference to it, Kerbrat-Orecchioni's argument resonates with Widdowson's (2004) distinction between *text* and *discourse*. As Widdowson (2004: 8) argues, "identifying something as a text is not the same as interpreting it." Whereas a *text* is "the language people produce and which provides objective data for linguistic analysis" (Widdowson 2004: 8), *discourses* can only be inferred from texts. "Discourse," Widdowson (2004: 8) continues, "in this view is the pragmatic process of meaning negotiation. Text is its product."

A participant as an objective fact would thus be a category of *text*, whereas a party would have to be inferred from the conversational text and as such constitute a category of *discourse* rather than text. In that sense, Kerbrat-Orecchioni is right in pointing out that the notion of party belongs "to another level of analysis." The same pertains to the interpretation of simultaneous speech: overlap is a text phenomenon, i.e., that there is simultaneous talk is an observable fact. However, the significance of this overlap for the participants is a *discourse* phenomenon, which can only be inferred by *interpreting* the text. Schegloff's (1995) argument that in order to assess the adequacy of the turn-taking model one needs to distinguish between overlap *within* and *across* parties then presupposes an analysis on the discourse level, as it is only at this level that we can identify parties and discuss their interpretation of overlap in the first place.

This now raises the question whether turn-taking as such is a feature of texts or of discourses: if turn-taking organizes the allocation of speaking turns among parties, as Schegloff (1995) argues, then it follows that turn-taking must operate on the discourse level. It would be premature to come to a final verdict on this matter based on the preliminary analysis of the two extracts discussed above. Nevertheless, as I hope to have shown, the questions related to the notion of party and turn-taking in group interactions would be worthwhile pursuing in a more systematic way, preferably by the empirical analysis of video recordings of group interactions in various languages and settings.

A final remark as to how these observations relate to the study of English as a lingua franca. Although I have drawn my examples of turn-taking from ELF data, the issue of parties and persons in relation to simultaneous talk does not arise only in the analysis of ELF but is equally relevant for all multi-participant interactions, whatever language is used. However, as I indicated at the beginning of this paper, it was the process of analyzing ELF data that first alerted me to this issue. I found, as other researchers have done (see, e.g., Osimk-Teasdale's [2014] article in a previous issue of this journal) that the various non-conformist ways in which ELF users exploit their linguistic resources cannot be

satisfactorily accounted for in reference to established categories and procedures of analysis. In consequence, the study of ELF interactions raises questions about how generally valid these categories and procedures are. The very nature of ELF communication challenges us to rethink taken-for-granted assumptions based on conventional uses of language that have become so familiar that we hardly ever pause to question their validity.

Moreover, while these observations are not uniquely applicable to ELF, they may well be particularly *relevant* for ELF research. Since ELF speakers come to their interactions from different lingua-cultural backgrounds, it is more likely that there will be greater need to negotiate roles of persons and parties – and the larger and more heterogeneous the group, the greater the need for negotiation. It is not surprising, therefore, that many of the features that have been described as characteristic of group interactions, such as their flexibility, fluidity, and their dynamics, have also been identified as "typical" of ELF interactions. And what Bruxelles and Kerbrat-Orecchioni (2004) have to say about polylogues equally applies to ELF interactions: "this is what makes them not only challenging but also of major interest for the analysis of talk in interaction" (Bruxelles and Kerbrat-Orecchioni 2004: 110).

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Bionote

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